Design Zero-shot, One-shot, and Few-shot Prompts to Generate a Professional Email Requesting Leave Due to Illness

Aim

To design three prompting methods for generating a professional illness leave email and compare the sample emails based on tone, grammar, formatting, and completeness.

Algorithm

1. Read the sender details, recipient, leave dates, illness reason, and work handover information.

2. Create a common instruction requiring a polite email with a subject, salutation, reason, dates, approval request, and closing.

3. Prepare zero-shot with no examples, one-shot with one example, and few-shot with two examples.

4. Enter each complete prompt into the same language model using the same settings.

5. Review the responses for tone, grammar, formatting, and completeness. Check that no medical details or promises were invented.

Prompting Methods

Zero-shot gives only instructions. One-shot adds one example. Few-shot adds multiple examples showing the expected style and structure.

Prompt Designs

Common Instruction

Write a professional email requesting leave due to illness. Use only the supplied details. Include a subject, salutation, brief reason, exact leave dates, approval request, and polite closing. Mention handover only if supplied. Do not invent a diagnosis, medical certificate, or availability during leave.

Zero-shot Prompt

Use the common instruction followed by the target details in the Input section. Supply no examples.

One-shot Prompt

Use the common instruction, Example 1 below, and the target details.

Example request: Anika requests personal leave from Ms Rao for 12 November 2026; her urgent tasks are handed to Rohan.
Example email:
Subject: Personal Leave Request - 12 November 2026
Dear Ms Rao,
I request personal leave for 12 November 2026. I have handed my urgent tasks to Rohan. Kindly approve my request.
Thank you for your consideration.
Regards,
Anika

Few-shot Prompt

Use the common instruction, Example 1 from the previous page, Example 2 below, and the same target details.

Example request: Vikram requests leave from Mr Das for a family commitment on 18 November 2026; no handover details are supplied.
Example email:
Subject: Leave Request - 18 November 2026
Dear Mr Das,
I request leave on 18 November 2026 due to a family commitment. Kindly approve my leave for that day.
Thank you for your understanding.
Regards,
Vikram

Python Program

Python 3 prompt builder; no external packages are required. It prints prompts to paste into a language model. It does not generate emails automatically.

```
instruction = input("Common instruction: ")
example1 = input("Example 1 (one line): ")
example2 = input("Example 2 (one line): ")
details = input("Target leave details: ")
prompts = {
    "Zero-shot": instruction,
    "One-shot": instruction + "\n" + example1,
    "Few-shot": instruction + "\n" + example1
                + "\n" + example2
}
for name, prompt in prompts.items():
    print("\n" + name + " PROMPT")
    print(prompt + "\nTarget details: " + details)
```

Input

Enter the common instruction and the two complete examples above. For each example, enter its request and email on one input line, separated by spaces.

Target details: Sender: Sai Jagadeesh. Recipient: Mr Kumar. Reason: feeling unwell. Leave: 21-22 October 2026. Handover: urgent tasks shared with Priya. Request approval. Do not promise availability during leave.

Output: Illustrative Emails

The following are prepared sample responses to the three prompt designs. They are not outputs from an external model run.

Zero-shot Email

Subject: Sick Leave Request - 21-22 October 2026
Dear Mr Kumar,
I am feeling unwell and request sick leave for 21 and 22 October 2026. I have shared my urgent tasks with Priya. Kindly approve my leave for these two days.
Thank you for your understanding.
Regards,
Sai Jagadeesh

One-shot Email

Subject: Leave Request Due to Illness - 21-22 October 2026
Dear Mr Kumar,
I am feeling unwell and would like to request leave for 21 and 22 October 2026. I have shared my urgent tasks with Priya. Please approve my leave request.
Thank you for your consideration.
Regards,
Sai Jagadeesh

Few-shot Email

Subject: Sick Leave Request - 21-22 October 2026
Dear Mr Kumar,
I request sick leave for 21 and 22 October 2026 as I am feeling unwell. I have shared my urgent tasks with Priya. Kindly approve my leave for the stated dates.
Thank you for your understanding and consideration.
Regards,
Sai Jagadeesh

Comparison of the Sample Emails

Zero-shot

Tone: Polite and direct. Grammar: Correct sentence structure and punctuation. Formatting: Clear subject, salutation, paragraphs, and signature. Completeness: Includes the illness reason, both dates, handover, and approval request.

One-shot

Tone: Courteous and slightly softer through "would like to request". Grammar: Correct and natural. Formatting: Follows the example structure consistently. Completeness: Includes every supplied detail without adding unsupported claims.

Few-shot

Tone: Formal and respectful. Grammar: Correct, with concise wording. Formatting: Consistent with both examples. Completeness: Includes all required details; the closing is slightly longer than necessary.

Result

All three sample emails are professional, grammatically correct, clearly formatted, and complete. One-shot and few-shot examples help specify a consistent format, but these samples do not establish a universal quality advantage. Actual model responses should be compared under the same settings before selecting the preferred method.